

BEST FOOT FORWARD
Nitish Kumar at a rally for JD(U) candidate Alok Kumar Suman in Gopalganj, May 19

NITISH PLAYS THE END GAME

AMID FREQUENT ALLIANCE SHIFTS, AN UNDERCURRENT OF ANTI-INCUMBENCY AND RISING OPPOSITION, CHIEF MINISTER NITISH KUMAR FIGHTS TO PROTECT HIS LEGACY OF GOVERNANCE AS WELL AS HIS OWN FUTURE

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

On **MAY 19, AS THEIR HELICOPTER** whirred to life after a public meeting in Gopalganj, Bihar, its chief occupant, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, began flipping through a set of papers. The other two passengers—state water resources minister Vijay Choudhary and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Jha—mostly kept quiet, responding only if asked something work-related.

The documents that the Janata Dal (United) supremo was rifling through contained data on the various welfare schemes of his government, such as the number of rural roads built and the number of students benefitting from the state-run polytechnic in Siwan—his next stop for another rally. Once he finished speed-reading a page, Nitish stacked it meticulously so that all the pages were aligned. It is with the same precision that Nitish is approaching the Lok Sabha election in his state, which his party, the Janata Dal (United) is fighting as part of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

Pulling Out All the Stops

The current term of Bihar's legislative assembly comes to an end in November 2025. Until then, the state's longest-serving chief minister is fairly secure, after having walked over to the BJP side in January. But things may not be as hunky-dory 18 months down the line. Especially amid suggestions that people may be growing weary of Nitish helming the state. His frequent switcheroos, from the NDA to the *mahagathbandhan* with the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and the Congress, and back again, haven't gone down well with the electorate. Not to mention the several conspiracy theories doing the rounds that the BJP may attempt to eat into Nitish's vote bank and diminish his influence post-election.

These are reasons enough for Nitish to stake his all this election. A strong performance will galvanise his party cadre and supporters for yet another shot in the assembly polls next year, but